

Misunderstandings of local people began immediately: soon after the foundation of Jamestown, the first English colony in Virginia in 1607, its leader John Smith assumed that Powhatan people taking part in a puberty ceremony were sacrificing their own children. Misreadings have continued to this day.

People of the frozen north

Europeans first came into contact with the Inuit people of Greenland and the Canadian Arctic in the 1500s, when voyagers were sent out to explore the Northwest Passage, a waterway believed to connect the Pacific and the Atlantic. The harsh Inuit environment fostered a need for cooperation and a belief in *Innuu* (the spirit powers who controlled their frozen surroundings).

Inuit *angakkuq* (spiritual healers), resembling the shamans of Siberia, mediated with the spirit world and guided their communities in the rites necessary to ensure *Innuu* favored them. It was believed to be especially important to appease the Old Woman of the Sea, known in Greenland as *Arnarquagssag*, who had created the sea creatures, such as seals, on whom the Inuit depended for survival. If angered, the Old Woman was said to keep the sea creatures away from people, causing hunger and hardship.

This world view was not fully understood by Christian missionaries when they began to evangelize the Inuit in the 1890s. Inuit beliefs in creatures of vengeance such as the *tupilaq*, created by a sorcerer from animal parts and even the corpses of children, were seen by these missionaries as a species of witchcraft.



◀ Brutal encounters

This painting portrays a clash between Inuit people and mariners from the English expedition of Martin Frobisher at Bloody Point on Baffin Island in 1577. Violent skirmishes deepened the misunderstanding of native beliefs and led to mutual mistrust.

British folk magic

There was some melding of European and local magic. In British colonial North America, some Native American beliefs merged with the religions of enslaved Africans and with English folk magic (see pp.202–203), while the Catholic use of holy water, candles, and relics found a counterpart in the local lore of Puritan New England. For example, Tituba, enslaved by Samuel Parris, the minister in Salem during the 1691–1692 witch trials, was said to have made a cake using urine, an old English folk remedy. In Connecticut, a Native American offered a receptive settler “two things brighter than day ... Indian gods,” showing that local religion remained vibrant and offered magical solutions to colonizers who were open to them.

“It was a usual thing for people to cure hurts with spells.”

COTTON MATHER, *WONDERS OF THE INVISIBLE WORLD*, 1693

► Book of charms

This 17th-century book shows a patriarchal cross, designed to protect the reader from violence, illness, and demons. The book and its contents are typical of the mix of religious fervor and magical belief that circulated in colonial New England.

